

3. Source: Statement from the UN Humanitarian Coordinator in Beta to HfA, passed on by informants to local tribal leadership.

The UN Humanitarian Coordinator expresses profound gratitude for "Health for All's" endeavors in Beta. The UN is deeply concerned about the worsening security conditions in the country's rural regions, with the incident involving Health for All's staff being particularly alarming. Predominantly, security in these areas is managed by tribal chiefs, with minimal intervention from government or military forces.

That said, the UN was taken aback by Health for All's sudden decision to leave Beta without extensive consultations with the local government or tribal leaders. This move is uncharacteristic of the organization's reputed standards. The HfA claims that a swift operational shift was required by increasing demand for surgical care in Gamma, which led to the prompt relocation of the country director to Gamma City. The lack of leadership in Beta caused a communication gap regarding the organization's changing priorities.

This oversight was regrettable. The HfA team affirmed that given the circumstances, Health for All is now keen on ensuring open dialogue with communities and tribal leaders, especially concerning the release of their staff. The organization stands firm on its redeployment to Gamma due to depleted funds for Beta operations. Major donors like Germany and Switzerland have mandated the transition of all medical resources and staff to Gamma. The objective now is to transition the Beta Town hospital's control to local health officials, with the financial assistance from developmental agencies. Health for All's surgical team in Beta Town, primarily trained for war-related injuries, mostly cater to road accident victims.

While global conflicts indeed result in wartime casualties, Beta's dilapidated health infrastructure makes it resemble a perpetual conflict zone. It's distressing that global aid organizations are pivoting towards richer nations despite the continued humanitarian needs in places like Beta.

We urge HfA foster meaningful conversations with tribal leaders. It is the only way to bring about the safe release of the staff. However, caution is advised concerning local security personnel, many of whom had affiliations with violent factions during past conflicts. These guards can be unpredictable and potentially dangerous, as can some tribespeople. Ensuring the safety of Health for All's staff and residences is paramount. Recent intel from partners in Beta Town suggests potential demands for ransom by tribespeople for the release of HfA staff. Our Security Coordinator suggests hiring expert negotiators to handle the hostage situation. The UN has reliable contacts who can ensure minimal ransom payouts.

While grateful, HfA clarified that their organization adheres to a strict no-ransom policy in hostage situations. If they begin paying ransoms in one region, they might face similar demands elsewhere, compromising their principles. Meanwhile, no ransom have been demanded so HfA will insist to deal with this situation as a labor dispute rather than a hostage situation. The Security Coordinator wished HfA well and reiterated his offer of providing seasoned negotiators.